

SIDDARAMAIAH
75; Congress

The Congress's crowd-puller who crafted his political image as a backward classes' leader, Siddaramaiah is the only Karnataka CM to complete a full five-year term (2013-2018) since D. Devaraj Urs in 1978. The big turning point in his political career came in 2005 when—after two decades in the Janata Party and its successive avatars—he fell out with mentor H.D. Deve Gowda and joined the Congress. Known as an able administrator, Siddaramaiah not only presented 13 state budgets as finance minister but also led the Congress's charge in the assembly as Leader of Opposition. Now, he is eyeing a second stint as CM.

D.K. SHIVAKUMAR
60; Congress

In times of crisis, he's the Congress's go-to guy. Always game for a fight, Shivakumar played a key role in 'safeguarding' his party's MLAs during the scramble for power that resulted from a hung assembly in May 2018. The previous year, he had famously helped the late Ahmed Patel secure his Rajya Sabha win in a similar fashion. Congressmen say his tenacity and loyalty to the party won him Sonia Gandhi's appreciation. Among the richest MLAs in the state with assets worth Rs 1,358 crore, he belongs to the influential Vokkaliga community. After taking over as the Karnataka Congress chief in 2020, he now dreams of becoming the CM.





GETTY IMAGES

H.D. KUMARASWAMY
63; JD(S)

In his second stint as CM in 2018, Kumaraswamy described himself as a "child of circumstances". This was because the JD(S) was leading a coalition government with the Congress despite being the junior partner. But how he first catapulted to the centre stage of Karnataka politics in the previous decade was a different story altogether. In 2006, as a first-time MLA, he staged a coup that brought down the then Congress-JD(S) coalition, much to the dismay of his father H.D. Deve Gowda, and became CM for the first time. Both the stints were short-lived. He is now eyeing a third term, for which he has pulled out all the stops, including a four-month-long road campaign during which he put in 18-hour workdays despite having undergone heart surgery twice.

Veerashaiva-Lingayats are greater in number. The party has given tickets to 51 Lingayat candidates this election, an increase of eight seats over the previous elections.

As regards seat distribution in the Congress, the party was flooded with over 1,350 applications for the 224 seats. Vallabh says the KPCC screening committee scrutinised each application using criteria such as the applicant's commitment to the Congress ideology and to the development of the area where he or she is seeking a ticket from, besides assessing the candidate's winnability. Senior leaders were put on the job to talk to those who were rebelling and explain to them the party's rationale. As a result, more than 90 per cent of the disputes were settled. So much so that C-Voter's daily tracker shows that the Congress still has the edge a fortnight before voting date, giving it anything between 105 and 125 seats, while the BJP is hovering at around 80 seats and the JD(S) around 30 seats. The agency's founder-director, Yashwant Deshmukh, enumerates two reasons why the Congress remains the frontrunner. "There is an emotion for change," he says. "What we are seeing is a routine anti-incumbency against the BJP government coupled with the fact that the Congress has a strong alternative leader like Siddaramaiah."

FENDING OFF ANTI-INCUMBENCY

Anti-incumbency remains a significant impediment for the BJP. To counter it, the party has replaced 20 sitting MLAs with new candidates and brought in fresh faces overall in about 80 constituencies. That's more than a third of the seats that the BJP is contesting. These decisions, the party says, were made after several rounds of surveys and assessments. As a party